monastic libraries of local communities housed the palm-leaf manuscripts that served as repositories for textual study. Monks were expected to stay removed from worldly affairs and not challenge traditional authority.

During the early colonial period, Christian schools were established first by the Portuguese and later by Roman Catholic and Baptist missionaries. Upon their arrival, the British encountered an established system of Buddhist education that had produced a high rate of literacy among the general population. Following the Anglo-Burmese war, the British government began to develop educational policies for its Indian colonies. The primary objective was secular in nature. An additional purpose was to instill an appreciation for European civilization.

Educational reform during the late-19th century greatly influenced the history of Burma. Overall colliding worldviews and political agendas defined the debate regarding education in Burma. The nationalist leaders in Burma used education to form and shape public opinion in their struggle for independence.

Monastic resistance to colonial policy increased during the 1860s when Sir Arthur Phayre proposed granting financial assistance to lay teachers in rural settings. This change led to an increase in young talent leaving the traditional Buddhist educational track. The movement to place education in secular hands was a legacy of colonialism that left a vacuum in Burmese life, for the specifically Buddhist nature of the traditional learning process was lost in the transfer to lay schools. The introduction of colonial knowledge through modern educational reforms challenged Buddhist cosmological worldviews. In a decision that proved to be a turning point in the history of education in Burma, the sangha, the Buddhist community, firmly rejected British attempts to introduce new educational subjects into the monastic curriculum.

In general, the sangha objected to the teaching of mathematics, geography, and drawing but was even more angered by the explicit government intrusion into the management and operations of the schools. The sangha feared its authority and autonomy would be compromised by cooperation with a colonial power; this refusal to collaborate with colonial authorities accelerated the decline of monastic education. This in turn fragmented an institution that had considerable power during royal times.